

PHIL 340 Examination

Comparative Philosophy: East and West – Answer Key

1. **(B)** The action can be willed as a universal law without contradiction.
Kant's Categorical Imperative requires that moral maxims be universalizable. An action is permissible only if its underlying principle could be willed as a law for all rational beings without logical contradiction or undermining itself.
2. **(B)** *Wu wei* (effortless action or non-interference).
Wu wei is central to Daoism, emphasizing spontaneous, natural action aligned with the Dao (the Way). It suggests acting without forcing, allowing things to unfold naturally rather than imposing artificial structures.
3. **(B)** A disposition to act according to the mean between extremes.
For Aristotle, virtue (*arete*) is a state of character concerned with choice, lying in a mean between two vices (excess and deficiency). For example, courage is the mean between cowardice and recklessness.
4. **(B)** *Anatta* (non-self).
Anatta is the Buddhist doctrine that there is no permanent, unchanging self or soul. All phenomena, including persons, are composite, impermanent, and interdependent. This is one of the Three Marks of Existence in Buddhism.
5. *Sample answer:*
Similarities:
 - Both emphasize duty and moral obligation over consequences
 - Both stress the importance of cultivating moral character
 - Both reject pure consequentialism
 - Both value universality (Kant's maxims, Confucius's reciprocity)**Differences:**
 - **Foundation:** Kant grounds morality in autonomous reason and categorical imperatives; Confucius grounds it in social relationships and tradition (*li*, ritual propriety)
 - **Focus:** Kant emphasizes abstract, universal principles independent of context; Confucianism emphasizes particular relationships (filial piety, loyalty) and social harmony
 - **Method:** Kant uses rational formalism; Confucianism uses exemplars and cultivation of virtues like *ren* (benevolence)
 - **Application:** Kant seeks absolute moral laws; Confucianism allows flexibility based on relationships and circumstances
6. *Sample answer:*
Atman in Hindu philosophy:
 - *Atman* is the eternal, unchanging self or soul that persists through reincarnation
 - It is distinct from the physical body and empirical ego

- The ultimate goal in Hinduism is realizing that *Atman* is identical with *Brahman*, the universal, absolute reality: “Tat Tvam Asi” (That Thou Art)
- This realization leads to *moksha* (liberation from the cycle of rebirth)

Contrast with Buddhist Anatta:

- Buddhism explicitly rejects the existence of *Atman*
- According to *Anatta*, there is no permanent self; what we call “self” is a collection of five aggregates (*skandhas*): form, sensation, perception, mental formations, consciousness
- These aggregates are impermanent and constantly changing
- Liberation (*nirvana*) comes from realizing this non-self and letting go of attachment to the illusion of a permanent identity

7. Sample answer:

Plato’s Theory of Forms: The physical world is a realm of imperfect copies; true reality consists of eternal, immutable Forms (or Ideas) existing in a transcendent realm.

Epistemological implications:

- True knowledge (*episteme*) is of Forms, not sensible particulars
- Sensory experience provides only opinion (*doxa*)
- Knowledge is *anamnesis* (recollection): the soul knew the Forms before birth and recalls them through philosophical inquiry

Metaphysical implications:

- Addresses the problem of universals: what all triangles share is participation in the Form of Triangle
- Forms are causally explanatory: things are what they are by participating in Forms
- The Form of the Good is the highest Form, source of truth and reality (Allegory of the Cave)

Problem of universals: How can many particular things share the same property? Plato answers: by participating in a single universal Form that exists independently.

8. Sample answer:

Radical freedom: Sartre argues that humans are “condemned to be free.” We have no fixed nature or essence; existence precedes essence. We constantly create ourselves through choices.

Authenticity vs. Bad faith:

- **Authenticity:** Acknowledging radical freedom, taking responsibility for choices, living consciously without self-deception
- **Bad faith:** Self-deception where one denies freedom by pretending to be determined by external factors (social roles, past, others’ expectations). Example: a waiter who identifies completely with his role, denying his freedom to be otherwise

Moral responsibility:

- With radical freedom comes absolute responsibility: we cannot blame circumstances, upbringing, or nature for our choices
- We create values through our choices; there are no objective moral facts
- This can lead to existential anguish (*angoisse*) as we confront the weight of our freedom

Sartre's existentialism challenges us to live authentically by embracing our freedom and accepting full responsibility for our lives.